



Gone are the days of straitjacketed relationships defined by propriety and social acceptance; today, what's sauce for the goose is sauce for the gander

RINKU SACHDEVA MURDER

ACCUSED: Husband Amit Budhiraja

CAUSE: SUSPICION OVER EXTRA-MARITAL AFFAIR

DATE: March 22, 2008

PLACE: Bangalore

THE CASE: Infosys engineer Amit Budhiraja smothered his wife of one year after an argument over her alleged affair with a colleague. He also left a suicide note on his intention to kill her and himself. The two had met on a marriage portal. The police have not been able to establish Sachdeva's extra-marital relationship.

tor, gender studies, etc: "Social norms have granted financial autonomy to the woman but are still iron-cast in not accepting her liberty in sexuality. A woman's new economic entity is coming into sharp and often violent conflict with the husband-controlled sexuality."

Clearly, the social fabric is changing and so are urban Indians. "Beneath the veneer of development, there are highly literate and educated men who cannot handle empowered women and that can cause a lot of tension within marriages or relationships," says Donna Fernandes of Bangalore-based women's support group Vimochana.

Along with Nokia and Coke, we have also become net importers of social and sexual habits that are alien to a society which in some ways is still anchored in traditions where sex is only a tool for procreation and not pleasure. Few men want to accept that India is in the grips of a sexual revolution, which is threatening the power equation that has historically existed between the

two genders. The protagonist of India's sexual revolution is not the philandering male, but the Indian woman.

The new India is fast coming unhinged from the conventional *Bharat*, where Ram and Sita are role models only for a generation that has gone by. As HBO makes inroads into villages, an alternative morality is fast pervading Indian society, where men and women are on a treadmill of perpetual pleasure and spouses are plotting to kill each other so that they can be with someone else. In this new India, highs come from diverse avenues like substance abuse, success, glamour and quest for limitless sexual gratification. No longer do human resource managers raise eyebrows when drains of a call centre in Bangalore are found clogged with condoms, as the Janes and Johns by night emulate the American culture they espouse all through their working hours.

A survey conducted across India's leading call centres shows that 38 per cent respondents are fine with pre-

CASE FILES

Jain, kidnapped and murdered councillor Atmaram Gupta, as she was opposed to his closeness with another woman councillor. The Jains and four others were sentenced to life.



Gupta

VICTIM: Shabana Malik

ACCUSED: Momin Malik

CAUSE: SUSPICION OF EXTRA-MARITAL AFFAIR WITH A LOCAL POLITICIAN

DATE: May 11, 2008

PLACE: Mumbai

THE CASE: Momin Malik stabbed his wife Shabana to death for her alleged affair with a local politician.

TEENAGERS

VICTIM: Karishma Shah

ACCUSED: Hemant Misal

CAUSE: JEALOUSY

DATE: May 21, 2008

PLACE: Pune

THE CASE: Shah's friend from college, Hemant Misal, attacked her with a knife for being friends with other boys, he disapproved of. The 16-year-old Misal had even warned the boys of dire consequences if they continued to be friends with Shah.

OTHERS

VICTIM: Anandharaman

ACCUSED: Wife Vidhyalakshmi and her boyfriend Anand

CAUSE: FORCED MARRIAGE AND HER RELATIONSHIP WITH ANOTHER MAN

DATE: June 20, 2007

PLACE: Munnar

THE CASE: Vidhyalakshmi, 24, helped her lover Anand, an auto-rickshaw driver, kill her newly-minted husband Anandharaman on their honeymoon. She had been forced into the marriage. Police traced the crime trail by tracking their sms exchange. Both have been sentenced to a double life sentence.